



Discussion Guide: Lauren Winner

Magnolia Trees and Cardigan Sweaters: Unexpected Metaphors for God

Reflect

- How would you define a metaphor? Do you think we use them simply to make our language sound more beautiful? If not, what's the value of using metaphors, whether in talking about God or any other subject?
- Lauren notes that some metaphors for God are more commonly used than others. What are some of the most common metaphors for God that you regularly hear or use in your community of faith (in prayers, liturgy, music, etc.)? Try to come up with a top 10 list.
- Lauren draws our attention to several under-utilized metaphors for God in the Bible, including mother hen, cheesemaker, giant tree, mourner, and seamstress. Which of these caught your attention? What aspect of God's character or way of relating to us does that metaphor illuminate for you?

Respond

- Choose several of the common metaphors for God you named in response to the second question above. What draws you to these metaphors? Do you see any limitations to them? If so, what are they?
- Lauren proposes that all created things are "obscurely yet unmistakably saturated with the personality and the passion of their creator." What do you think of this idea? If she's right, does that mean that anything in creation can be a metaphor for God in some way?
- Come up with your own metaphor for God you would like the church to use more. Why are you drawn to this image?